Hebrew but often prefer to consume the news in their first language. Channel 9, a Russian-language station, serves the million-plus Israelis who emigrated from the former Soviet Union. Native English speakers can choose from a plethora of newspapers and websites, plus a new television network, i24, which also broadcasts in French and Arabic. So the Hebrew media have a limited audience at home, and almost none abroad: most Jews in the diaspora cannot speak Hebrew well enough to read *Yediot Aharonot* or watch the Israeli news.

The country's most popular network, Channel 2, is run jointly by two companies called Reshet and Keshet. The prime minister has proposed breaking it apart, arguing that a split would encourage diversity and competition. It would also force both companies to hire their own news teams, at a cost of perhaps tens of millions of dollars, and strip Channel 2 of its status as the country's leading evening news program. "Israel is a small media market, and we can't export our news," said Amit Segal, the Channel 2 political correspondent. "So it would be better to have one big channel than two smaller ones that probably wouldn't be viable."

Channel 10, the country's most liberal, narrowly escaped bankruptcy in 2015 after an arcane licensing dispute. It blamed the prime minister for its financial woes, because he blocked a deal to settle the channel's long-standing debts. The network is seen as Israel's most edgy, and a perennial thorn in Netanyahu's side: its top investigative correspondent, Raviv Drucker, has doggedly pursued stories of official corruption, and once took the prime minister to court to find out how often he speaks with Adelson. Both channels are still operating normally, but the threat lingers. "Netanyahu is almost obsessed with the media, so it's amazing he's done nothing yet," Segal told me in early 2016. "But he wants us to know that he has his finger on the button."

The specter of "reform" also hung for years over the Israel Broadcasting Authority, which operated the state-run Channel 1 and several radio stations. For decades, the IBA was funded by a license fee, charged to any household with a television—whether or not they used it to watch IBA's dated programming. The Knesset voted to abolish the fee in 2014, partly due to reports that the broadcaster had spent 30 million shekels on lawyers to chase down families who didn't pay.

Around the same time, the poorly-managed IBA was declared bankrupt. The communications minister at the time, Gilad Erdan, drew up plans to